

Exploring the Language of Display

Exploring the Language of Display

Module Code: ARTD6218

Assignment Title: Illustrated Report On Practice

Word Count: 2481

Date of Submission: 14th, May2

Contents

Chapter 1	Introduction	1
Chapter 2	Find your place within the rhythm of Korea: <i>FREQUENCY: KOREA</i>	2
2.1	Concept Statement	2
2.2	Site Context and Design Response	4
2.3	Entrance Design	6
2.4	The K-passport	7
2.5	Gateway of First Light	11
2.6	The Marketplace Design	12
2.7	The Courtyard Design	21
Chapter 3	Conclusion	25
	Reference List	27

List of Figures

Fig. 1	Composite Moodboard: Material, Light and Mediated Korean Aesthetics.	2
Fig. 2	DESIGN MARKET of PMQ in 2014.	4
Fig. 3	Circulation strategy for FREQUENCY: KOREA, illustrating the bifurcation of visitor movement into Haptic and Optic experiential routes in response to the spatial constraints of PMQ. Diagram by author (2026).	5
Fig. 4	Entrance Design of FREQUENCY: KOREA showing dual-frequency distribution system and spatial flow differentiation.	7
Fig. 5	K-passport Identity System	8
Fig. 6	K-Culture Identity Bracelet Design	9
Fig. 7	AR Projection Mirror: Interactive mirror system that overlays holographic dance content linked to the exhibited costume.	10
Fig. 8	Gateway of First Light Layout.	11
Fig. 9	The tactile transition of the flooring in the Marketplace experience.	13
Fig. 10	Material Wall Close-up	13
Fig. 11	Traditional Hanbok Material Tactility Zone	15
Fig. 12	The K-pop performance exhibition area	16
Fig. 13	Traditional Red-Blue Hanbok Inspired Stage Costume	18
Fig. 14	Hanbok-Adapted Stage Outfit for MV Performances	19
Fig. 15	Street-Style Y2K Hanbok-Adapted K-pop Stage Outfit	20
Fig. 16	Bridge of Time Runway During Live Fashion Performance	22
Fig. 17	Courtyard Day and Night Transformation Diagram	22
Fig. 18	Post-exhibition Market Zone	24

Chapter 1 Introduction

K-Culture in 2026 has achieved what Eugene Levy's journey proved: it has broken barriers. But the fact that the barrier is broken does not mean that the invitation has been accepted. For a person who has never heard of K-pop, has never eaten kimchi, and thinks that Hanbok is just a "drama costume", how can we turn curiosity into resonance?

This project aims to explore how design and scene art can transform this surface-level curiosity into deeper sensory and emotional engagement. This project is designed for the "Festive Korea 2026" event of PMQ in Hong Kong.

FREQUENCY: KOREA proposes an immersive exhibition environment that approaches Korean culture not as a static national identity, but as a series of overlapping sensory “frequencies” experienced through movement, materiality, atmosphere and participation.

Chapter 2 Find your place within the rhythm of Korea:

FREQUENCY: KOREA

2.1 Concept Statement

FREQUENCY: KOREA is a multi-channel cultural experience disguised as a fashion exhibition. A K-passport system is introduced to guide visitors through different cultural frequencies. As a result, *FREQUENCY: KOREA* has built a multi-level cultural field so that different interpretations can coexist here. What visitors experience is a selective interpretation shaped by how they choose to participate.

If we understand Korean culture as a series of signals, the main task of this exhibition is to translate these signals into materials, colors, light and forms(see Fig. 1).



Fig. 1 Composite Moodboard: Material, Light and Mediated Korean Aesthetics.

Source: Images generated using Midjourney and assembled by the author in Figma (2026).

This moodboard establishes a visual and sensory framework for *FREQUENCY: KOREA*, translating Korean culture into a system composed of material, atmosphere and mediated imagery.

Drawing on James J. Gibson's theory of perception (Gibson, 1979), the project begins with a focus on **material frequency**, where the textures of hanji and embroidered surfaces are positioned at the core of a tactile experience. These images frame culture as something encountered through surface, craft and touch, rather than symbolic representation alone.

The second layer introduces **light as atmosphere**, where lanterns, reflections and diffused illumination construct what John Berger describes as a *pre-linguistic mode of seeing* (Berger, 1972). Here, meaning emerges not through interpretation, but through embodied and intuitive spatial experience.

Finally, the integration of LED environments and neon corridors reflects a **mediated visual condition**, aligning with Jonathan Crary's concept of the *modern observer* (Crary, 1992). In this context, fashion becomes image, and space functions as a screen.

Rather than separating these layers, the moodboard integrates them into a **sensory system** in which tactile, optical and digital experiences coexist. This framework directly informs the spatial strategy of the project, enabling visitors

to navigate and perceive Korean culture through different perceptual “frequencies”.

2.2 Site Context and Design Response

This project is located in Hong Kong's cultural and creative landmark PMQ “Yuanchuangfang”. This venue is characterized by its open courtyard layout and flexible activity space. However, while this openness brings convenience and public participation, it also exposes a core limitation that is, some previous cultural activities often lead to the fragmentation of tourists' experiences, and various activities are scattered in space, lacking a clear narrative vein (see Fig. 2).



Fig. 2 DESIGN MARKET of PMQ in 2014.

Source: https://www.pmq.org.hk/media/Design_market_01.jpg

This picture shows that tourists tend to interact with isolated scenic spots in previous activities. For example, watching performances, patroning food stalls or checking in installation art cannot form a coherent understanding of cultural content. Due to the lack of a clear spatial sequence, the whole experience is simplified into simple visual consumption rather than cultural interpretation.

In response to this limitation, the project proposes a structured yet non-linear spatial strategy (see Fig. 3), transforming the originally open site into a coherent experiential system.

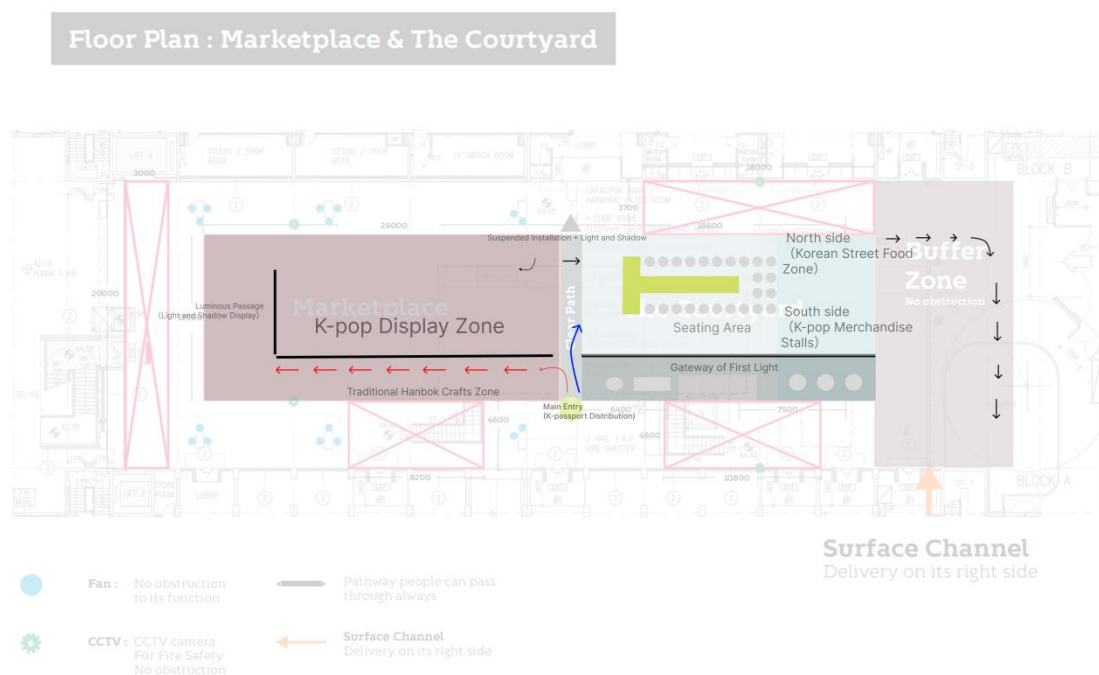


Fig. 3 Circulation strategy for FREQUENCY: KOREA, illustrating the bifurcation of visitor movement into Haptic and Optic experiential routes in response to the spatial constraints of PMQ. Diagram by author (2026).

Figure 3 illustrates the circulation strategy developed for *FREQUENCY: KOREA*, responding to the linear layout of the PMQ site and the constraint of the central fire corridor. The scheme adopts a structured but non-linear approach, allowing visitors to choose between two experiential routes rather than being directed along a fixed path.

At the entrance, circulation splits into two, forming a moment of “frequency selection”. This reflects James J. Gibson’s concept of *affordances*, whereby spatial design suggests possible actions without enforcing them (Gibson, 1979). This spatial layout also echos the concept of "exhibitionary complex" proposed by Tony Bennett (1995), that is, the flow and viewing behaviour of the public, which is actually implicitly organised and disciplined through the display structure and spatial sequence.

The **Optic Frequency** route (right) is open and flexible, encouraging social interaction through media, seating and food-related elements. In contrast, the **Haptic Frequency** route (left) forms a more controlled loop within the Marketplace, guiding visitors through a sequence of experiences centred on materiality and tactile engagement.

2.3 Entrance Design

The design of the entrance (see Fig. 4) operates through a set of distributed element systems. Two small distribution points are set up on both sides of the path, and the staff distributes "K-passports" to visitors to divert the flow. The

direct passage on the left is a light and shadow corridor built by the left building and the KT version, which extends horizontally to the interior of the venue. In contrast, the right side remains open to guide visitors directly into the Buffer Zone and the subsequent streamline.

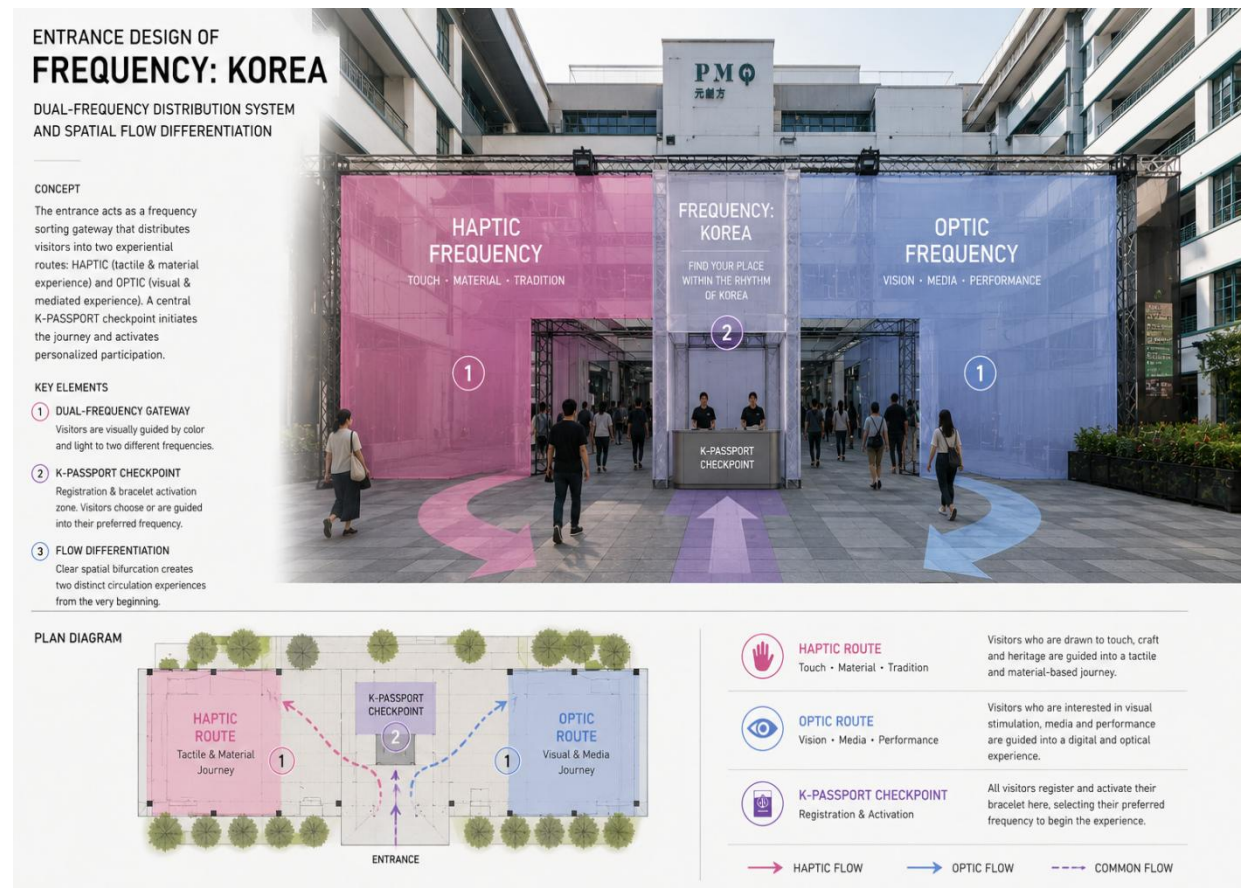


Fig. 4 Entrance Design of **FREQUENCY: KOREA** showing dual-frequency distribution system and spatial flow differentiation.

Source: Author's own image generated using ChatGPT and composed in Figma (2026).

2.4 The K-passport

The design of the passport is inspired by contemporary Korean fan culture, travel documents and media objects with collection value. Each passport presents a unique visual identity through color, font and graphic language, allowing visitors to immediately associate themselves with a specific cultural

participation model. This system maps the phenomenon that contemporary Korean culture is often experienced through identity participation, fan circle affiliation and personalized consumption.



Fig. 5 K-passport Identity System

Source: Author's own design generated using ChatGPT(2026).

As shown in Figure 5, the event designs four passport identities: **Dancer**, **Stylist**, **Chef** and **Collector**. Each identity has a unique sense and cultural perspective. Visitors can choose their preferred role at the entrance. After receiving the corresponding passport, they can get the recommended route and collect the corresponding seal, and can also get different secret experiences with different passports. The audience doesn't need to do any extra movements. They only need to wear a bracelet (see Fig.6) and stay

naturally in front of a specific exhibit or area. The NFC chip embedded in the bracelet will be read by the sensor buried on the ground or in the booth at close range (within about 1.5 meters), triggering the hidden content of the corresponding channel.



Fig. 6 K-Culture Identity Bracelet Design

Source: Author's own design generated using ChatGPT(2026).

This design approach reflects Michel de Certeau's concept that movement through space itself becomes a cultural practice rather than a purely functional action (de Certeau, 1984). At the same time, the use of wearable technology transforms the exhibition into what Jonathan Crary describes as a mediated perceptual environment, where attention, movement and visual

experience are continuously structured through technological systems (Crary, 1999).

The **Dancer** passport provides a clear example of this interaction logic. When visitors wearing dancer bracelets approach the K-pop stage clothing device, an augmented reality (AR) window will be activated automatically.



Fig. 7 AR Projection Mirror: Interactive mirror system that overlays holographic dance content linked to the exhibited costume.

Source: Author's own design generated using ChatGPT & Midjourney(2026).

2.5 Gateway of First Light

The Gateway of First Light is the first immersive transition space in the **FREQUENCY: KOREA**, which aims to instantly isolate visitors from the surrounding urban environment and guide them into a sensory journey. This corridor uses a threshold space full of atmosphere, where light, material and dynamics begin to build the emotional rhythm of the exhibition together.

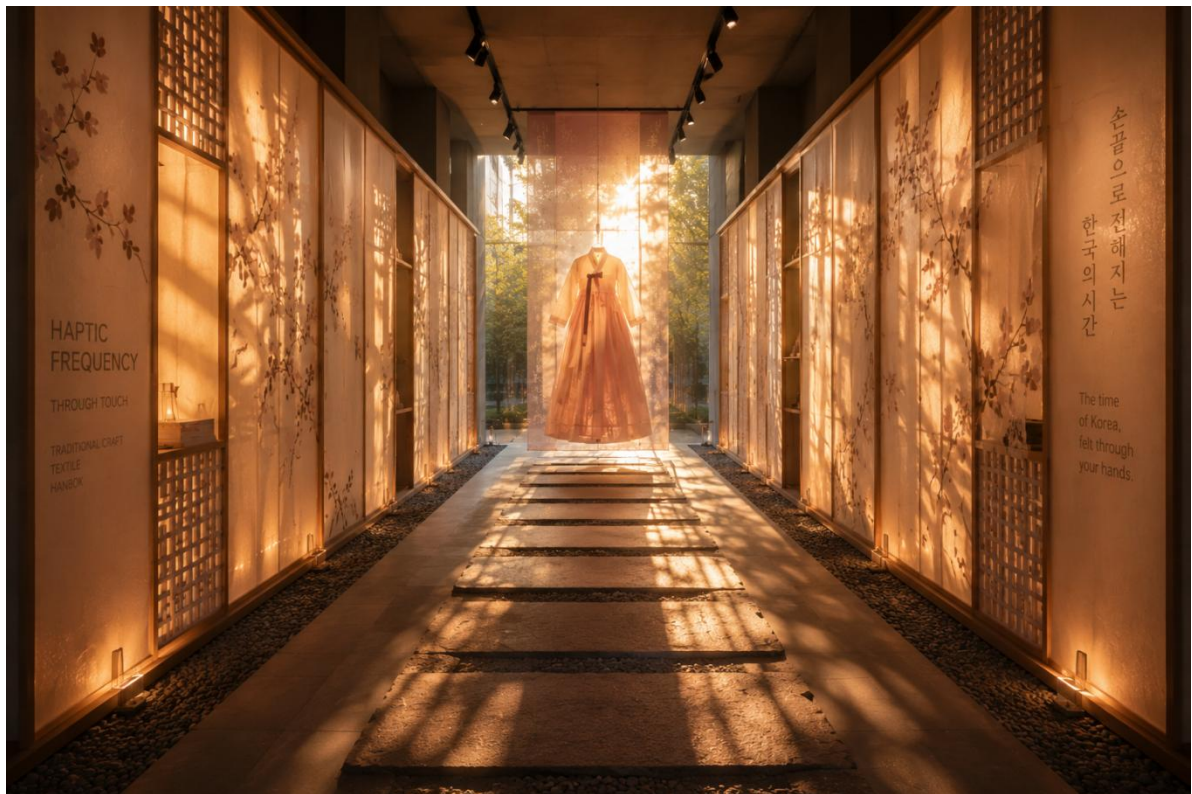


Fig. 8 Gateway of First Light Layout.

Source: Author's own design generated using ChatGPT & Midjourney(2026).

The space consists of a temporary corridor structure built between the existing PMQ building and a series of translucent KT board partitions. Both sides of the passage are lined with translucent Korean paper surfaces, so that the warm light can be gently diffused in the corridor. When visitors pass

through it, the shadows, contours and reflections will change with the pace, creating a sensual environment that is both private and cinematic.

At the center of the corridor,

stage costumes inspired by contemporary K-pop and reinterpreting the aesthetic of Hanbok hover like ethereal objects amid light and shadow. Unlike the static, secluded display of garments in conventional museums, these costumes are presented as dynamic cultural signifiers, highlighting their fluidity across the stage, the human body, and visual communication.

2.6 The Marketplace Design

After passing through the morning light corridor, visitors entered the market area. At this time, the first change noticed was the change of ground materials. The originally rough stone strips in the corridor gradually disappeared and were replaced by smooth ceramic floor tiles (see Fig.9). This subtle tactile transition marks that visitors have officially stepped into a more immersive sensory exhibition environment from the ritual-filled traditional entrance of Korea.

At the market entrance is a tactile sensory wall, inlaid with six real 20×20 centimetre material samples. Visitors are invited to touch these materials with their own hands, instead of just looking from afar (see Fig.10).



Fig. 9 The tactile transition of the flooring in the Marketplace experience.

Source: Author's own design generated using ChatGPT & Midjourney(2026).



Fig. 10 Material Wall Close-up

Source: Author's own design generated using ChatGPT & Midjourney(2026).

The samples cover six textures: raw ramie fibre with a slightly sharp, rough touch; finely woven ramie fabric with dense weave lines; smooth silk that feels cool to the touch and carries a subtle sheen; soft Korean Hanji paper with a warm, natural fibrous texture; mother-of-pearl lacquer pieces with a glass-like cool sleekness; and modern stage performance fabric that is slightly elastic and features heat-retaining functionality.

Beside the material wall hangs a specially recreated Hanbok top, displayed openly without any glass enclosure. Crafted with exactly the same materials and traditional sewing techniques used for classic Hanbok, this piece is intentionally designed as an interactive exhibit for the public. Visitors are welcome to touch the smooth silk surface, feel the thickness of the embroidery, and experience the fabric's weight and natural drape through direct physical contact. Unlike conventional museum displays that isolate fashion artifacts behind glass barriers, this installation transforms the costume into a fully embodied, sensory experience.

This design approach echoes the viewpoint of Juhani Pallasmaa, who argues that architectural and spatial experience should engage the entire body, rather than relying solely on visual perception. Touch here becomes a way of understanding culture, allowing visitors to engage with Korean material culture through intimate physical contact instead of distant visual observation (Pallasmaa, 2012).



Fig. 11 Traditional Hanbok Material Tactility Zone

Source: Author's own design generated using ChatGPT & Midjourney(2026).

Then, the route transitioned to the K-pop performance exhibition area (see Fig.12). Six to eight sets of K-pop stage costumes are displayed in the window here. There is an LED light strip hidden inside each window, emitting a faint internal glow. At the back of each set of costumes, a LED screen continuously plays slow-motion footage of the costume being worn during a real K-pop stage performance. These videos are deliberately slowed down to 75%, allowing visitors to notice subtleties that are usually overlooked in fast-paced performances, such as fabric movement, reflective textures, and choreography-driven clothing dynamics. This approach reflects the idea of “slow looking” in exhibition design, which encourages audiences to spend

more time observing visual details and material qualities that are often missed in rapid visual consumption (Tishman, 2018).



Fig. 12 The K-pop performance exhibition area

Source: Author's own design generated using ChatGPT & Midjourney(2026).

In terms of detailing, the costumes feature extensive use of embroidery, patchwork prints, and fluid strap designs. As performers dance, their voluminous sleeves and trailing ties create distinct kinetic trajectories with every movement, amplifying the visual recognizability of stage choreography. As emphasized by research in stage costume studies, K-pop styling is designed to retain strong visual memorability even under high-speed camera shots, dramatic stage lighting, and social media dissemination (Oh, 2021).

For instance, Figure 13 presents a stage costume reconstructed based on the traditional red-and-blue Hanbok. Through dragon-pattern embroidery, layered skirt panels and asymmetrical strap details, the design reinterprets traditional royal totems into a visually expressive language with heightened stage dramatic tension. The stylistic contrast between elaborate heavy embroidery and the short-skirt structure endows the costume with both a sense of historical heritage and the powerful aura inherent in idol culture.



Fig. 13 Traditional Red-Blue Hanbok Inspired Stage Costume

Source: Author's own design generated using Midjourney(2026).

Figure 14 further emphasizes the soft, dreamlike visual aesthetic of female idol imagery. The design retains the lightweight fabrics and floral patterns characteristic of traditional Hanbok, while incorporating cropped waist cuts,

pearl embellishments, and pastel colour palettes to align closely with the contemporary visual paradigm of K-pop girl groups. Costumes of this kind are repeatedly viewed across music videos, live stage performances, and fan-shared media footage.



Fig. 14 Hanbok-Adapted Stage Outfit for MV Performances

Source: Author's own design generated using Midjourney(2026).

Figure 15 presents another street-fashion-oriented style of K-pop stage look. Featuring an asymmetrical off-shoulder design, tailored slim cuts, and mixed printed patterns, the costume further integrates traditional Hanbok elements

into the aesthetic context of Y2K and idol fashion. This design reflects how contemporary K-pop continuously engages in visual reconstruction, transforming traditional culture into a consumable, shareable, and globally recognizable pop cultural image.



Fig. 15 Street-Style Y2K Hanbok-Adapted K-pop Stage Outfit

Source: Author's own design generated using Midjourney(2026).

These costumes exist not merely as exhibits, but also as spectacle objects. As Guy Debord (1967) argued, the spectacle in modern society shapes human desire and cultural identity through visual systems. Within the

Gateway of First Light, vision intertwines with multiple sensory dimensions.

The moment visitors encounter these Hanbok-reimagined K-pop stage outfits upon entering the exhibition, they are immediately immersed in the sensory atmosphere constructed by K-culture.

2.7 The Courtyard Design

The courtyard is accessible both from the market zone and via the branching pathways near the entrance, serving as the central open gathering space of the entire exhibition.

The courtyard center features the Bridge of Time runway, which acts as the visual and spatial heart of the entire exhibition. This lengthy T - stage (see Fig.16) stands as the undeniable focal point of the courtyard. During scheduled fashion shows, models parade along the runway wearing Hanbok inspired K-pop stage costumes previously displayed in the exhibition zone. When fashion performances are not taking place, the runway transforms into an open participatory stage. The space regularly hosts K-pop random dance events, taekwondo demonstrations, and casual audience interactive sessions. Visitors are also encouraged to try on the costumes freely and walk onto the T-stage to take photos.



Fig. 16 Bridge of Time Runway During Live Fashion Performance

Source: Author's own design generated using Midjourney(2026).

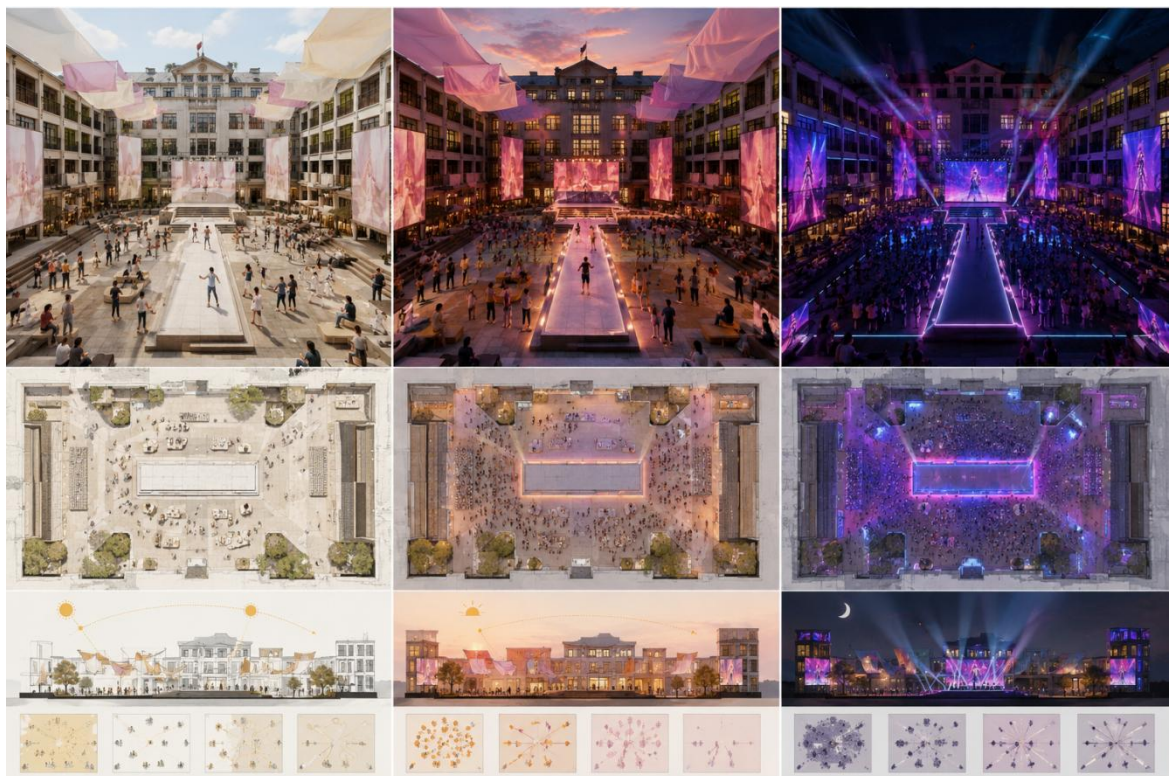


Fig. 17 Courtyard Day and Night Transformation Diagram

Source: Author's own design generated using Midjourney&ChatGPT(2026).

Lighting plays a crucial role in transforming the courtyard's atmosphere from day to night (see Fig.17). During the daytime, the space remains relatively open and natural, utilizing soft reflected sunlight and hanging translucent fabric banners (inspired by bojagi), the traditional Korean wrapping cloth. At this time, the environment feels light, social, and festive, supporting catering activities and casual interactions. As night falls, the scene gradually shifts into a more cinematic spectacle. Concealed LED light strips embedded along the edges of the runway light up sequentially, while projection mapping spreads across the surrounding PMQ buildings. The lighting tone transitions from warm daylight hues to the saturated pink, blue, and violet frequencies associated with contemporary K-pop stage aesthetics. Mist and reflected light enhance the visibility of movements and silhouettes, transforming the courtyard into a fully mediated nighttime performance space.

Finally, near the exit area, there is a small post-exhibition market zone (see Fig.18). This space allows visitors to further extend their connection with Korean culture through food or collectible media items before leaving the exhibition.



Fig. 18 Post-exhibition Market Zone

Source: Author's own design generated using Midjourney&ChatGPT(2026).

The space features four small stalls, arranged symmetrically along the exit path. Two of these stalls focus on Korean street food culture, serving popular treats such as tteokbokki and hotteok. Parallel to the food stalls are pop-up retail displays offering idol merchandise and Korean cultural goods, including photocards, stylized passport stickers, exhibition-exclusive postcards, and miniature Hanbok-stage-costume key chains. Here, collectibility and visual identity affiliation become the core drivers of consumer desire.

Chapter 3 Conclusion

FREQUENCY: KOREA explores how the scenographic display transforms the cultural exhibition from a passive viewing environment to a participatory sensory experience. This project does not present Korean culture as a fixed national image, but transforms it into a series of spatial "frequency" systems expressed by light, material, movement, sound and media performance. Throughout the exhibition, visitors are encouraged to shuttle through different experience routes, interact with tactile materials, contact digital media systems, and directly participate in the space of collective performance.

By integrating the two display modes of haptic and optic, this project shows how the exhibition design can synchronise the audience's perception and emotional input. The integration of wearable interactive systems, ambient lighting transitions, and performing public spaces allows visitors to switch freely between the roles of observers, participants and performers. In this context, display no longer exists only as a visual presentation, but evolves into an active cultural interface shaped by embodied experience.

In the end, *FREQUENCY: KOREA* put forward a view that the experience of contemporary K-culture is not achieved through a singular representation, but circulation, participation and spectacle. Therefore, this exhibition is no longer a static display of Korean identity, but a temporary immersive environment in

which visitors build their own cultural connection through their own movement, interaction and memory.

Reference List

Gibson, J.J. (1979) *The Ecological Approach to Visual Perception*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin.

Berger, J. (1972) *Ways of Seeing*. London: Penguin.

Crary, J. (1992) *Techniques of the Observer: On Vision and Modernity in the Nineteenth Century*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

Bennett, T. (1995) *The Exhibitionary Complex*. In: *The Birth of the Museum: History, Theory, Politics*. London: Routledge.

Debord, G. (1967) *The Society of the Spectacle*. Paris: Buchet-Chastel.

Oh, C. (2021) *K-pop Style and Visual Performance Culture*. Seoul: Korean Cultural Studies Press.

Pallasmaa, J. (2012) *The Eyes of the Skin: Architecture and the Senses*. 3rd edn. Chichester: Wiley.

Tishman, S. (2018) *Slow Looking: The Art and Practice of Learning Through Observation*. New York: Routledge.

Pmq.org.hk. (2026). Available at:
https://www.pmq.org.hk/media/Design_market_01.jpg [Accessed 10 May 2026].

Midjourney (2026) *Midjourney AI image generator*. Available at:
<https://www.midjourney.com> (Accessed: 9 May 2026).

OpenAI (2025) *ChatGPT (GPT-5.5) [Large language model]*. Available at:
<https://chat.openai.com/> (Accessed: 9 May 2026).

Figma (2026) *Figma design platform*. Available at: <https://www.figma.com> (Accessed: 11 May 2026).